

Adherence to the WCRF/AICR guidelines for cancer prevention is associated with lower mortality among older female cancer survivors

Background The 2007 World Cancer Research Fund/American Institute for Cancer Research (WCRF/AICR) guidelines encourage cancer survivors to follow its cancer prevention recommendations. We evaluated whether adherence to the WCRF/AICR guidelines for cancer prevention was associated with lower mortality among older female cancer survivors. **Methods** From 2004–2009, 2,017 participants in the Iowa Women's Health Study who had a confirmed cancer diagnosis (1986–2002) and completed the 2004 follow-up questionnaire were followed. Adherence scores for the WCRF/AICR guidelines for body weight, physical activity, and diet were computed assigning one, 0.5 or 0 points to each of eight recommendations depending on the degree of adherence. All-cause ($n=461$), cancer-specific ($n=184$), and cardiovascular disease (CVD)-specific mortality ($n=145$) were compared by the total adherence score and by adherence scores for each of the three components of the recommendations. **Results** Women with the highest (6–8) vs. lowest (0–4) adherence score had lower all-cause mortality ($HR=0.67$, $95\%CI=0.50–0.94$). Meeting the physical activity recommendation was associated with lower all-cause ($ptrend<0.0001$), cancer-specific ($ptrend=0.04$), and CVD-specific mortality ($ptrend=0.03$). Adherence to dietary recommendations was associated with lower all-cause mortality ($ptrend<0.05$), whereas adherence to the body weight recommendation was associated with higher all-cause mortality ($ptrend=0.009$). **Conclusions** Adherence to the WCRF/AICR guidelines was associated with lower all-cause mortality among older female cancer survivors. Adherence to the physical activity recommendation had the strongest association with lower all-cause and disease-specific mortality. **Impact** Older cancer survivors may decrease their risk of death by leading a healthy lifestyle after a cancer diagnosis.